

Resource: Tyndale Open Study Notes

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Themes)

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Tyndale Open Study Notes

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Rebuilding of Jerusalem

The wall of Jerusalem held great political, social, and religious importance for the people of Judah (see [Nehemiah 2:10, 19; 4:1-15; 6:1-14](#)). In ancient and even modern times, a city without walls cannot last long. Walls protected cities from invading armies and common criminals.

By Nehemiah's time, Jerusalem's walls had been in ruins for over a hundred years, since the city's destruction in 586 BC. The ruined wall was a shameful reminder that God had punished the city, fulfilling the covenant curses due to the people's sins ([Nehemiah 1:2-7; 2:17](#)). Rebuilding the wall would show God's blessing and prove that he was restoring the covenant people. Israel's enemies knew that if they rebuilt the wall, the Jews would gain political power, security, and self-rule. Therefore, they strongly opposed the rebuilding.

Under Nehemiah's leadership, the people of Judea rebuilt the entire wall in just fifty-two days during the fall of 445 BC. This quick and successful reconstruction can encourage Christians that with God's help, they can achieve remarkable things (see [Nehemiah 2:18; 4:14-15, 20; 6:16](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Nehemiah 1:2-4; 2:10-20; 3:1-32; 4:1-23; 6:1-16; Psalm 51:16-18; Isaiah 22:5; 26:1-3; Revelation 21:10-27](#)

Religious Hypocrisy

Religious hypocrisy happens when people selectively obey rules and only pretend to follow God's law without real change in their motives and lives. Those who boast about their religious commitment often lack a true desire to obey God.

The prophet Isaiah preached to people who seemed to be very religious. They fasted, prayed, celebrated holy days, and brought sacrifices to Jerusalem. Yet God rejected these practices.

Why? These acts had value because the Lord himself had prescribed them! But the people's worship was not sincere. It lacked the personal holiness and social justice that God requires (see, for example, [Leviticus 19:13-17](#)). The people of Judah had become religious hypocrites.

Many years after Isaiah, Jesus addressed the hypocrisy of the Pharisees. He urged them to obey all of what God had revealed, not just the parts that made them popular ([Matthew 23:1-36](#), especially [Matthew 23:23](#)). The apostles Paul and James also emphasized the difference between performing religious acts and having true spirituality ([1 Corinthians 3:1-23; James 1:21-2:13](#)).

Jesus' criticism of the Pharisees also warns us. We should not imitate them (see [Matthew 6:1-18; 1 Peter 2:1](#)). Instead, Jesus tells us to be genuine with God and others and obey all his commands. In our worship of God, we must go farther than religion forms with a focus on outward actions.

Passages for Further Study

[Psalm 50:16-23; Proverbs 15:8; 26:23; Isaiah 1:11-15; 29:13-15; 58:2-7; Jeremiah 7:4-10; 12:2; Ezekiel 33:30-31; Hosea 8:13; Amos 5:21-24; Micah 3:11; Zechariah 7:5-6; Malachi 2:13-14; Matthew 6:1-18; 23:1-36; Titus 1:15-16; James 1:21-27; 1 Peter 2:1; 1 John 2:4, 9; 4:20](#)

Remaining in Christ

The Greek term *menō*, often translated as "remain," "stay," or "abide," appears often in Jesus' teachings about deep, intimate, and lasting relationships. For example, Jesus said, "If you continue in [*menō en*, 'stay in'] My word, you are truly My disciples" ([John 8:31](#)). This means the life of a follower of Jesus (a disciple) is fully shaped by Jesus' message.

Jesus also explained how the Son is in the Father and the Father is in the Son ([John 14:10-11](#)). In a similar way, when we remain in Jesus, the Son is in us, and we are in the Father and the Son ([17:21-](#)

[23](#)). Both the Father and the Son come and make their "home" within disciples.

This mutual "living inside" shows what it means for a disciple to remain in Jesus. We cannot make our relationship permanent by ourselves. Only God's gracious action through his Holy Spirit makes the relationship lasting. Both God and the disciple must commit. The connection between God and the disciple is not temporary. It is a lasting and eternal relationship (see [1 John 2:14, 17](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 33:11](#); [34:28](#); [Joshua 7:11-12](#); [1 Samuel 16:22](#); [Psalms 22:11, 19](#); [101:7](#); [Daniel 1:21](#); [2:49](#); [Haggai 2:5](#); [Luke 15:31](#); [22:28](#); [John 6:56](#); [8:31](#); [15:1-17](#); [Philippians 4:1](#); [1 John 2:19, 27-28](#); [3:24](#); [2 John 1:9](#); [Revelation 2:10](#); [13:10](#)

Remember Him

God saved the Israelites from slavery in Egypt and made them his people. Yet, God knew they would forget him ([Deuteronomy 31:16-21](#)). Moses warned the people entering the promised land to always remember what the Lord had done for them ([Deuteronomy 8:1-20](#)). The Israelites eventually forgot the Lord, which led to their exile from the land God had given them (see [2 Kings 17:5-23](#); see also [Jeremiah 2:32](#)).

The Teacher in the book of Ecclesiastes emphasizes the importance of remembering the Lord. Throughout the book, the Teacher reflects on how many aspects of life are temporary and useless or meaningless. He concludes by urging readers to remember the one who is eternal ([Ecclesiastes 12:1-7](#)). No one stays young forever, aging and death are universal.

Therefore, the Teacher encourages people to focus on God while they are young, before it is too late. All people are accountable to God for their actions ([Ecclesiastes 12:13-14](#)). Our present lives should be guided by the reality of his future judgment.

Passages for Further Study

[Deuteronomy 8:1-20](#); [Ecclesiastes 12:1-7, 13-14](#); [1 Corinthians 3:12-14](#)

Remove the Evil

Sin is so opposed to God's holiness that it cannot exist with him. The same should be true for God's

people. God is holy, and he expects his people to show his holiness ([Leviticus 11:45](#); [19:2](#)).

God required severe responses to remove sin from the covenant community. God offered forgiveness, but only to those who were truly repentant. Those who became stubborn could expect God's judgment. This judgment was a cleansing process that consumed sinners and their sins, leaving nothing behind (see [Deuteronomy 9:3](#); [13:5](#); [Isaiah 33:14](#); [Hebrews 12:28-29](#)). This cleansing is meant to heal the community of believers in the Lord and discourage others from rebelling against him ([Deuteronomy 17:13](#)).

In the Old Testament, God often judged his people immediately (see, for example, [Numbers 11:1-3](#); [16:1-50](#); [Joshua 7](#)). This made his people very aware of his demand for obedience and the consequences of disobedience.

God's final punishment is set for the future day of justice when he will reveal and judge the sins of all people ([Romans 14:10](#); [2 Corinthians 5:10](#); [Hebrews 9:27](#); [1 Peter 4:5](#)). Yet, some disasters can be seen as God's judgment on his disobedient people (for example, [Acts 5:1-11](#); see [1 Corinthians 11:27-30](#)). It is still "a fearful thing to fall into the hands of the living God" ([Hebrews 10:31](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Leviticus 19:1-2](#); [Deuteronomy 9:3-6](#); [13:5](#); [17:2-13](#); [Joshua 7:1-26](#); [2 Chronicles 34:3-8](#); [Isaiah 1:24-26](#); [4:2-6](#); [33:14](#); [Ezekiel 20:32-38](#); [Matthew 18:8-9](#); [Acts 5:1-11](#); [Romans 14:10](#); [1 Corinthians 11:27-30](#); [2 Corinthians 5:10](#); [Hebrews 9:27-28](#); [10:31](#); [12:28-29](#); [James 5:19-20](#); [1 Peter 4:5](#)

Resurrection in the Old Testament

Many Old Testament passages suggest that the place where dead people are is a location from which people do not return (see, for example, [Job 7:6-21](#); [Psalm 6:5](#); [Isaiah 38:18-19](#)). Yet, some passages suggest the idea of that people can live again after death (see, for example, [Job 19:25-27](#); [Psalm 16:10-11](#); [Isaiah 26:19](#)). [Daniel 12:1-3](#) teaches that God will bring the dead back to life. God told the prophet Daniel that he would be part of this resurrection ([12:13](#)). Belief in the resurrection of the dead became more common during the period between the Old and New Testament writings. This was shown by the popularity of the idea during the time of Jesus.

According to this passage from Daniel, the resurrection will be different for people.

Two groups will resurrect:

1. Those who will experience new life.
2. Those who will experience shame.

These groups have different beliefs about right and wrong, different standards for behavior, and different ways of following God. The resurrection will reveal a person's true nature. Everyone will be accountable to God Most High in a moral and spiritual way.

The first group will have a new life called "everlasting life." In the Old Testament, this phrase appears only in [Daniel 12:2](#). Here it seems to refer more to the quality of life than its length. God will cleanse and purify those who experience this life. The similes "shine like the brightness of the heavens" and "shine like the stars forever and ever" describe their moral glory.

The second group will encounter everlasting shame and disgrace because they are not morally or spiritually renewed. The New Testament book of Revelation expands on these two groups from Daniel's vision (see [Revelation 20:4-6, 11-15](#)).

God's people will finally escape death. Those resurrected to life have their names written in the Book of Life (see [Daniel 7:9-10; 10:21; Revelation 20:12](#)). The Judge, known as the Ancient One, declares them righteous.

Passages for Further Study

[Job 19:25-27; Daniel 12:1-3, 13; Matthew 27:50-53; 28:1-20; 1 Corinthians 15:1-58; Revelation 20:1-15](#)

Retribution

God gave humans the task of having children and taking care of the world ([Genesis 1:28](#)). Yet, as the population increased, so did spiritual evil, violence, and murder ([4:8, 23; 6:5, 11-13](#)). This led to a corrupt world that required cleansing.

The purpose of the great flood during the time of Noah was to cleanse the world and retribution against those who did wrong. *Retribution* means "giving what is due" and usually refers to a penalty for bad actions. Retribution comes from the belief that the world has a moral order, which must be

maintained or restored (see [Psalm 7:14-16; Proverbs 11:17-21; 26:27](#)).

God keeps moral order by giving justice, punishing evil actions, and rewarding good behavior ([Galatians 6:7-8](#)). Since God oversees the world, it never becomes totally overcome by moral disorder. People are accountable to God for their actions.

Some examples of God's justice are:

- The judgment and exile of Adam and Eve from the garden of Eden ([Genesis 3:8-24](#));
- Cain's punishment for killing his brother Abel ([4:10-15](#)); and
- The worldwide flood ([chapters 6-7](#)).

These events show a God who rules over everything and gives fair punishment as part of his good plans for the world (see also [Numbers 16; Deuteronomy 30:15-20; Joshua 7; Micah 2:1-3](#)).

Retribution is one way God shows his righteousness. It cleanses the world for his kingdom of peace. Through retribution, God announces his rule over all and exercises justice against those who reject his rule or defy his commands ([Deuteronomy 7:10; Psalm 149; Proverbs 15:25; Micah 5:15; 1 Corinthians 16:22; Galatians 1:8-9; 2 Thessalonians 1:5-10](#)).

For God's people, retribution acts as his discipline. It intends to restore their covenant relationship with him (see [Isaiah 44:22; Jeremiah 3:12-14; Lamentations 3:19-33; Hosea 14:1-2; Joel 2:12-13](#); see also [Hebrews 12:5-11](#)). When God's people experience his discipline, they can respond with hope because God's truth and righteousness will win ([Psalm 58:10-11](#)). God will redeem and restore those who trust in him ([Leviticus 26:40-45; Hosea 2:2-23](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 6:1-7:24; Leviticus 26:14-39; Psalms 7:6-17; 57:6; 95:8-11; Proverbs 6:27-35; 26:27; Micah 2:1-3; Romans 2:5-16; Galatians 6:7-8; Hebrews 10:26-31; 12:5-11, 25-29](#)

Returning to the Lord

The Old Testament prophets often told the people of Israel to return to the Lord, both before and after the exile to Babylon (see, for example, [Isaiah 55:6-](#)

[7](#); [Hosea 6:1-3](#); [Haggai 1:12](#); [Malachi 3:7](#)). This meant a renewed commitment to obey God. They had abandoned the true God and started worshiping other gods, which led to his judgment. This judgment resulted in the destruction of the temple and their exile. The future restoration and blessing of God's people depended on their obedience to him.

The prophet Zechariah's main message to those returning to Jerusalem from exile is plain in his opening statement: "Return to Me, declares the LORD of Hosts, and I will return to you, says the LORD of Hosts" ([Zechariah 1:3](#)). Zechariah urged the people of Israel to renew their commitment to their special agreement with God (the covenant). He warned them to learn from their ancestors who were unfaithful to the covenant. This had severe consequences ([7:11-14](#)).

Zechariah cared about Israel's covenant with God and social justice. Returning to the Lord leads to obedience and practicing justice, honesty, fairness, mercy, and kindness ([Zechariah 7:9-10](#); [8:16-17](#)). Zechariah's focus on right relationships with God and others anticipated Jesus' teaching. He said the greatest commandments are to love God above everything and to love your neighbor as yourself ([Matthew 22:34-40](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[1 Samuel 7:2-11](#); [Isaiah 1:16-20](#); [55:7](#); [Hosea 6:1-3](#); [14:1-7](#); [Haggai 1:12](#); [Zechariah 1:3](#); [7:9-14](#); [8:16-17](#); [Malachi 3:7](#); [Matthew 3:2-10](#); [22:34-40](#); [Acts 17:24-31](#)

Rich and Poor in the Gospel of Luke

In Luke's Gospel, entering or becoming excluded from the kingdom of God involves a reversal of worldly wealth. Mary, the mother of Jesus, proclaimed that God would elevate the poor and humble while humbling the rich and powerful ([Luke 1:52-53](#)). Jesus declared in Nazareth that the gospel is "good news to the poor" ([4:18](#)). He blessed the poor and hungry and warned the rich and satisfied ([6:20-26](#)). This challenged the common belief that God blessed rich people and cursed poor people.

Several of Jesus' parables strongly warn about the danger of wealth. The parable of the rich fool shows what happens when someone stores up treasures on earth instead of building a strong relationship with God ([Luke 12:13-21](#)). The parable of the rich

man and Lazarus illustrates the eternal consequences of ignoring the poor and helpless while enjoying life's comforts ([16:19-31](#)). The rich man who asked Jesus how to gain eternal life felt devastated when Jesus told him to sell all he had and give to the poor ([18:18-23](#)).

Who are the poor in Luke's Gospel? Are they physically poor people or those poor in spirit (compare [Matthew 5:3](#))? It is probably both. The physically poor, who have very little, naturally depend on God for their needs. Rich and powerful people often rely on themselves, forgetting their need for God. Rich people cannot enter God's kingdom if they trust in their wealth to get them there ([16:25-26](#)). God accepts those who trust only in him.

Passages for Further Study

[Matthew 5:3](#); [Luke 1:52-53](#); [4:18](#); [6:20-25](#); [12:13-34](#); [14:12-23](#); [16:19-31](#); [18:18-30](#)

Righteousness by Faith

A key question in the early church was whether gentiles (non-Jewish people) who accepted the good news about Jesus needed to follow Jewish rules (including circumcision) to become part of God's family.

For the apostle Paul, the answer was simple. People cannot make themselves right with God by their own efforts. Only Jesus could accomplish (and has accomplished) what was necessary for reconciliation with God. Salvation is a gift of God's grace received through faith. Our response is to trust in Christ, give thanks for what he has done, and live in a way that reflects his love and truth.

For Jewish Christians in the first century, it was hard to accept this answer. From the time of Abraham, right relationship with God had been marked by circumcision, the ceremony of cutting off the male foreskin ([Genesis 17:9-14](#)). Every male who was part of God's family had to be circumcised, and those who neglected to do so were cut off from God's people. Those who had received circumcision were also expected to keep the rest of the law, including the Sabbath and dietary rules about food.

When Christianity spread from Jews to non-Jews, it was natural for questions to arise. Do Christians need to be circumcised (and keep God's law in general) to be accepted as part of God's family? Or

does God accept people because of their faith in Christ's work on the cross? As Paul's mission to gentiles advanced, these questions became urgent.

The apostle Peter understood from his vision in Joppa and his experience in Caesarea that God has accepted gentiles *as gentiles*, because of their faith in Christ's finished work ([Acts 10:9–11:18](#)). They did not have to become Jewish by practicing circumcision or the ceremonial laws. Christ provided them open access to God by faith. Peter and the Jerusalem church therefore welcomed gentile believers into fellowship. But later, Peter temporarily stopped eating with gentiles when some Jewish Christians criticized him ([Galatians 2:11–13](#)). In response, Paul rebuked Peter for suggesting that gentiles must become Jews in order to be accepted by God ([2:14–21](#)).

No one is made right with God by keeping the law ([Galatians 2:16](#)). Even Abraham was counted as righteous because of his faith ([Genesis 15:6](#); [Galatians 3:6](#); [James 2:21–24](#)). It was not because of circumcision, which came later ([Genesis 17:9–14](#)). Both Jews and gentiles are brought into right relationship with God through faith, which is a response to his grace.

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 15:6](#); [Habakkuk 2:4](#); [Acts 10:1–11:18](#); [Romans 1:17](#); [Galatians 2:14–21](#); [Galatians 3:11](#); [Hebrews 10:38](#)

Royal Psalms

The *royal psalms* all mention the king, his rule, and his relationship with God. Most scholars consider [Psalms 2, 18, 20, 21, 45, 61, 72, 89, 101, 110, 132, and 144](#) as royal psalms.

Belief in God's rule is the foundation of the royal psalms (see [Psalm 2](#)). Each king in David's family line (King David's dynasty) acted as a messianic agent. This means they represented God's rule. As God's representative, kings descended from David had the obligation to practice justice, righteousness, faithfulness, and peace ([Psalm 72:1–3](#)).

The royal psalms express the hopes and dreams of King David's dynasty. Because of its corruption and failure, the dynasty seemed to come to an end ([Psalm 89:38–45](#)). Yet, hope continued for a future king from David's family line to serve as God's Christ. The royal psalms keep this hope alive for a

king whose perfect obedience would guarantee the dynasty's continuation and the lasting benefits of his rule.

In this sense, one could also call the royal psalms *messianic psalms*. This is because they express hope in a Christ figure, the ideal king descended from David. Jesus stated that the writers of the psalms wrote about him ([Luke 24:44](#)). Other New Testament writers confirm that Jesus is the Messiah (God's chosen one).

Some of the most important connections to Christ are as follows:

- [Psalm 2](#) is associated with Israel's king, the descendant of David. Yet, it describes a global victory and rule that surpasses the time of David or Solomon's rule (see [Acts 13:33](#); [Hebrews 1:5](#); [5:5](#)).
- [Psalm 45](#) is a wedding song for a king descended from David, maybe Solomon. It also mentions a lasting rule ([45:6](#)).
- [Psalm 110](#) is the most quoted messianic psalm in the New Testament about Christ (see [Matthew 22:43–45](#); [Acts 2:34–35](#); [Hebrews 1:13](#); [5:5–10](#); [6:20](#); [7:21](#)). This psalm contains several key prophetic elements that were later understood as references to the Messiah. It describes the privileges, universal victory, and continual royal priesthood of David and his successors.

This language might seem exaggerated or misleading, except that it finds fulfillment in Jesus. The angels stand in God's presence (see [Luke 1:19](#)). But Christ the Son sits in a position of power and authority over everything at God's "right hand" ([Hebrews 1:13](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Psalms 2, 18, 20, 21, 45, 61, 72, 89, 101, 110, 132, 144](#); [Acts 2:34–35](#); [13:33](#); [Hebrews 1:5, 13](#); [5:5–10](#)